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After Gerald Ford won the nomination in Kansas City, I met with the members of the California delegation and said: “Nancy and I are not going back and sit on our rocking chairs and say, ‘That’s all for us.’”

Nancy was among those in the room that day with tears in her eyes. She had never tried to influence me, one way or the other, whether I should run for president, but I knew she felt a great sadness for me. She knew how much I hated to lose. In her heart, though, I think Nancy may have felt a sense of relief. Now we could go home and get on with the rest of our lives.

But I think we both knew it wouldn’t—couldn’t—end in Kansas City. After committing ten years of our lives to what we believed in, I just couldn’t walk away and say, “I don’t care any more.”

After the convention, I campaigned in more than twenty states for President Ford and when he lost to Jimmy Carter, I began writing my newspaper column and radio scripts again and continued to speak out for Republicanism and how we had strayed from the visions of our founding fathers. With contributions left over from the campaign, I established an organization called the Citizens for the Republic to focus attention on these concerns.

After Ford’s loss, I knew some of my supporters would begin knocking on my door and urge me to run in 1980, and they did. I told them I wasn’t going to make a decision yet.

I wasn’t the reluctant candidate I’d been in 1965 and 1976. I wanted to be president. But I really believed that what happened next wasn’t up to me, it was up to the